# STATE SCAN

**GUJARAT: CHAVDA FACES UPHILL CHALLENGE** *PG 20*

**TAMIL NADU: DEGREES OF PARALYSIS** *PG 22*



▶ BIHAR

# NITISH'S TEMPLE TANGO

**For the first time in his long political career, the Bihar CM adopts temple symbolism. A temple at Sita's storied birthplace aligns him to Hindutva**

*By* **Amitabh Srivastava**

**ON THE HUMID** morning of August 8 in Sitamarhi, ritual and pomp both arrived as if by appointment. A bhoomi pujan, a foundation stone, cameras arranging the moment into the traffic of images. Nitish Kumar spoke of Sita's birthplace, with no seeming trace of irony. His words bore echoes in their womb, and they were delivered right after, by Union home minister Amit Shah. He lauded "Nitish babu" for developing Punaura Dham, before moving on to sharper polemic—accusing political rivals of protecting alleged Bangladeshi infiltrators. With two months to go for the Bihar assembly election, the NDA's thematic duet was in full sync.

In a political career spanning over four decades, including nearly two as CM, this is perhaps the first time Nitish has so openly aligned himself with temple politics. If not exactly disenabling it under his reign, he had all through adhered to a personal political ethics that abjured it. Now here he was, tweeting and publishing full-page ads on the JD(U)-BJP government's Rs 882.87 crore project to redevelop the



*Illustration by* **SIDDHANT JUMDE**